assessed through a detailed reporting system. Each level had to provide regular reports that were cross-checked by a designated supervisor from the level above. As one of the cluster in-charges in Mathura explained, ‘Just before we met you, we were having a virtual meeting. One programme barely ends, and within two days, we get a list from the party for new programmes. At each level, we check if the president below us is working or not. From there, it will go to the national team. If they are not working, if they are not going to the field, we will appoint another one.’[44]

Even as the party decentralised, systematised digital lists of its active members right down to the booth level allowed greater oversight from the regional, state and national leadership. Where senior leaders were once dependent on local power networks that had their own dynamic, these databases allowed them greater direct outreach to the lowest-level worker. ‘We get a phone [call] daily from Lucknow,’ said one district-level leader. This was through a centralised call centre that put through calls between state-level leaders and booth-level workers. ‘They ask which all booths you went to, what are the issues, what work is going on? They want full feedback. It is not like they don’t know what is happening at the local level even if I say something ulta-seedha.’[45] Another explained that when local district officials sent lists of their office-bearers up the chain of command, ‘often they sent the list back, saying the phone numbers are not matching. They would have called and checked … Or sometimes they call a few presidents. They try two-three times. If there is no response, they come back to us, saying so-and-so booth president of yours is not working. Or such-and-such phone number is wrong. The big change is that they do this monitoring of our work. It is multi-layered and real-time.’[46]

The creation of a digital pipeline of communication, based on a booth-level enumeration and a centralised database, enabled party leaders to switch seamlessly to daily digital meetings with party workers on the Zoom app when physical outreach became restricted during the 2020 lockdown. In UP, a district vice president told me in July that his workers had not had ‘even one minute of rest’ during the lockdown. His team, he said, had never used Zoom before, but started doing ‘per day meetings’ on the app. ‘Sometimes we have